Futures Matter - Northwood

122 Emily Street, Highgate, Birmingham B12 0XJ

Unique reference number (URN): 152552

Pre-registration inspection report:	13 May 2026

Overall outcome	The school is likely to meet all the independent school standards if it is registered

The purpose of this inspection was to advise the Secretary of State for Education about the proposed school's likely compliance with the independent school standards and associated requirements that are required for registration as an independent school.

Part 8. Quality of leadership in and management of schools

When we carry out pre-registration inspections of proposed independent schools, we report on the provider's likely compliance with part 8 of the independent school standards first. Under part 8, the proprietor is required to ensure that the school meets all of the independent school standards consistently. The standard in part 8 is intended to ensure that the quality of leadership and management at the school is sufficient for that purpose.

The proprietor has a clear vision for the proposed school. Leaders are passionate about improving the lives of pupils with special educational needs and/or disabilities (SEND). They demonstrate high expectations for the quality of provision and have carefully considered the ethos and culture that they want to foster at the school.

The proprietor has established clear leadership structures to support the school's work. These structures include a governing body and a headteacher who is supported by a specialist consultant. Together they have a range of relevant experience in meeting the needs of pupils who are likely to attend the school.

The proprietor has completed work to address concerns about safety of the premises since the last pre-registration inspection. They have systems in place to monitor and check the school's compliance with the independent school standards

over time. These systems are likely to ensure that the standards are consistently met.

The proprietor has ensured that the standards in this part are likely to be met.

Part 1. Quality of education provided

Curriculum

Leaders have designed a broad and ambitious curriculum that is sequenced to build pupils' knowledge over time. The school has schemes of work in place that include pathways to various qualifications, dependent on pupils' needs, interests and ambitions. The curriculum's content reflects an inclusive ethos that promotes fundamental British values.

Leaders have considered the range of starting points that pupils may have when they join the school. They have ensured that pupils working below age-related expectations will learn foundational knowledge in subjects such as mathematics and English. Plans and resources are in place to prioritise the teaching of early reading through a structured phonics programme.

The proposed school intends to provide personal, social, health, and economic education (PSHE) along with materials that promote pupils' understanding of citizenship. Leaders have adopted schemes of work that include appropriate coverage of relationships and sex education and other themes that develop pupils' understanding of life in modern Britain.

A well-considered careers education programme has been prepared that is likely to support pupils in making decisions for their next stages of education, training or employment. The programme is planned to begin as soon as pupils join the school, with personalised pathways tailored to pupils' individual strengths, interests and aspirations. Leaders have begun to establish partnerships with an independent careers advisor and a local college to broaden pupils' access to guidance and opportunities.

Teaching and Assessment

The proprietor has recruited staff with experience of teaching pupils within the age range that the school intends to cater for. The headteacher demonstrates a secure understanding of effective classroom practice and has clear expectations for how the curriculum will be implemented. This school's curriculum policy includes approaches for staff to assess and support pupils' progress. An assessment framework is in place to help staff monitor the impact of pupils' learning over time.

The school's proposals include strategies for meeting the needs of the groups of pupils the provider proposes to admit. These strategies include adaptive teaching and practical approaches that, if implemented well, are likely to reduce pupils' barriers to learning.

The proprietor has ensured that classrooms are suitably furnished to support pupils' learning. They have begun to arrange teaching resources and have plans in place to provide additional resources as pupils' needs are identified.

The proprietor has ensured that the standards in this part are likely to be met.

Part 2. Spiritual, moral, social and cultural development of pupils

Leaders have planned a coherent approach to promoting pupils' spiritual, moral, social and cultural development (SMSC). This approach includes teaching information across the curriculum and through the wider life of the school. The school's curriculum includes subjects such as religious education, humanities and vocational studies that are designed to deepen pupils' understanding of culture and society. Leaders present a clear strategy for supporting staff in teaching and embedding SMSC at the school.

The teaching of fundamental British values is planned through curriculum content and reinforced through the ethos of the proposed school. The curriculum is likely to promote inclusivity and mutual respect.

The proprietor has ensured that the standards in this part are likely to be met.

Part 3. Welfare, health and safety of pupils

Safeguarding, admissions and attendance

The proprietor has established safeguarding procedures that reflect the guidance of the Department for Education (DfE). Leaders demonstrate a secure understanding of their responsibilities and have induction processes that are likely to ensure staff are vigilant in identifying pupils who need help.

The headteacher is trained to carry out the role of designated safeguarding lead (DSL) and has experience of working with pupils and families who need extra support. Leaders have considered the potential risks associated with the needs of pupils who may attend the school and have planned appropriate measures to promote their wellbeing. The school is well-prepared to work with external agencies to secure timely support for pupils when needed.

The school has a clear system for recording and reviewing safeguarding incidents. This record-keeping system is likely to support governors and proprietors in maintaining oversight of the school's safeguarding duties.

The school has a system in place to record admissions information when pupils join the school. In addition, leaders intend to use an electronic system for recording and monitoring pupils' attendance.

Behaviour, anti-bullying and supervision of pupils

The school's behaviour policy sets out expectations for pupils' behaviour and their attitudes to learning at the school. Leaders have worked to ensure the policy is implemented effectively through staff induction, training and ongoing support. These arrangements place emphasis on staff using de-escalation strategies and positive behaviour management techniques.

Leaders understand the needs of pupils who may attend the school. They have considered specific approaches to support pupils with SEND such as by using visual prompts, structured routines and clearly communicated expectations. A graduated approach has been prepared that includes the use of praise, rewards and restorative strategies.

Leaders understand the DfE's guidance regarding the use of restrictive interventions. They have included training for staff as part of induction to the school and also have appropriate systems for recording and reporting incidents.

The school has an anti-bullying policy that sets out clear expectations for pupils and staff. Leaders intend for pupils to be supervised at all times and have made plans for pupils to be taught in small groups.

Health and safety, fire, first aid and risk assessment

At the previous pre-registration inspection this standard was judged as not likely to be met because of hazards around the school's premises. Since then, the proprietor has acted quickly to address the issues that were identified. In addition, they have established systematic procedures to ensure that the premises and provision are maintained safely. They demonstrate a proactive approach through regular checks and monitoring arrangements that are designed to minimise risk.

Leaders have commissioned professional oversight to ensure compliance with fire safety requirements. A suitable fire risk assessment is in place, as well as clear procedures for maintaining equipment, training staff and practising evacuation routines.

Suitable arrangements are in place for administering first aid. This includes staff holding appropriate first aid qualifications and systems for recording incidents when first aid is administered.

Suitable risk assessments are in place. These assessments demonstrate the proprietor's understanding of safety planning. Leaders have considered a range of potential risks associated with the premises and the planned provision for pupils. For example, appropriate evaluations are already in place for pupils' use of off-site leisure centre facilities. The arrangements indicate a proactive approach to promoting pupils' safety and wellbeing.

The proprietor has ensured that the standards in this part are likely to be met.

Part 4. Suitability of staff, supply staff, and proprietors

The recruitment checks made on staff, supply staff and the proprietor. The single central record of these recruitment checks

The proprietor has clear procedures in place to check the suitability of staff, governors and proprietors. Leaders understand the principles of safer recruitment and have already implemented processes to make the necessary checks. These checks have been accurately recorded on the school's single central record

The proprietor has ensured that the standards in this part are likely to be met.

Part 5. Premises of and accommodation at schools

Toilet and washing facilities, water supply, changing accommodation and showers; medical room and accommodation for pupils' therapy needs

The school provides appropriate toilet and washing facilities for pupils. A well-equipped medical room is also available. The medical room includes necessary resources for administering first aid if necessary and is located near to a toilet.

The proprietor has arrangements in place for pupils' physical education at a local leisure centre. The leisure centre has changing facilities and showers. Leaders have completed a risk assessment on these arrangements and ensured that pupils will have sole use of the changing and showering facilities.

Ensuring the health, safety and welfare of pupils, lighting and acoustic conditions, outdoor space

The premises are well maintained and provide a clean and suitable learning environment. Each classroom benefits from sufficient levels of natural and artificial light and is decorated to a high standard. There are enough classrooms for the intended purpose of the school.

At the previous pre-registration inspection, this standard was judged as not likely to be met. Some areas of the school, including the outdoor space, were not suitable or safe for pupils. Since then, the proprietor has made the necessary changes to ensure the school is safe and suitable for pupils to attend. For example, the outdoor space has been levelled and paved. Timber cladding has made the playground walls safe, appealing and more conducive to playtime activities. Consequently, this standard is now likely to be met.

Part 6. Provision of information

The school provides a prospectus for pupils and parents. The prospectus includes necessary information about the school's ethos and also includes contact details of school leaders and the proprietor.

The school makes a range of policies available on request. These include the safeguarding policy and information about the school's approach to behaviour management and anti-bullying strategies.

Leaders understand their responsibilities to provide information to local authorities to support annual review processes for pupils with education, health and care (EHC) plans. They also have a system in place to report income and expenditure to authorities who commission places for pupils.

The proprietor has ensured that the standards in this part are likely to be met.

Part 7. Manner in which complaints are handled

The school's complaints policy sets out steps for parents to follow if they wish to raise concerns. The procedure prioritises an informal resolution but also includes a formal process that includes escalation to a panel hearing if needed. The panel includes a person who is independent from the school's management team. The policy defines clear timescales for the school to respond to a complaint.

The proprietor has ensured that the standards in this part are likely to be met.

The school's accessibility plan

The school has an accessibility plan that fulfils the requirements of schedule 10 of the Equality Act 2010.

About this inspection

Inspectors carried out this inspection under section 99 of the Education and Skills Act 2008, at the request of the registration authority for independent schools.

Inspectors checked the school's likely compliance with the independent school standards. These are the requirements set out in the schedule to the Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014.

Following our updated inspection framework, all inspections are now led by His Majesty's Inspectors (HMI) or by Ofsted Inspectors (OIs) who have previously served as HMIs.

The inspector spoke with members of the proprietor board and the headteacher during the inspection.

This was the second pre-registration inspection of the proposed school. The previous inspection was conducted on 14 January 2026.

Lead inspector

Jonathan Leonard	His Majesty's Inspector

About this proposed school

Chair of the proprietor body	Carrie-Ann McGurk
Headteacher	Eve Haynes
Type of school	Other independent special school
Capacity	20
Number of full-time pupils of compulsory school age on roll	Provider's proposal: 20
Number of part-time pupils of compulsory school age on roll	Provider's proposal: 0
Number of pupils with special educational needs and/or disabilities on roll	Provider's proposal: 20
Number of pupils on roll who have an education, health and care plan, or who are looked after by a local authority	Provider's proposal: 20
Age range of pupils	Provider's proposal: 11 to 16

Gender of pupils	Provider's proposal: Mixed
Total hours operating as a school per week	Provider's proposal: 32.5
Total hours of teaching provided per week	Provider's proposal: 32.5
Number of full-time equivalent teaching staff	Provider's proposal: 4
Number of part-time teaching staff	Provider's proposal: 0
Annual fees for day pupils	£65000
Email address	carrie-ann@futuresmattereducation.co.uk

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